

PARAGRAPH STRUCTURE

Organising your writing into clear blocks



1 What is it?

Paragraph Structure

Paragraph structure is how a writer **organises ideas into blocks of text** — each paragraph usually built around one central idea, image, or moment.

one idea = one paragraph

2 See it in action

A focused paragraph

Everything in the paragraph relates to one moment — a single scene, feeling, or idea.

A short paragraph for impact

He was gone. Three words. Its own paragraph, for maximum weight.

A new paragraph, new idea

A shift to a new character, place, or time usually signals a new paragraph.

Linking paragraphs

The last line of one paragraph sets up the first line of the next.



Mfalme says...

Before starting a new paragraph, check: **has something actually changed** — new idea, new moment, new speaker? If not, it probably belongs in the same paragraph.

FUN FACT

A single-sentence paragraph is one of the most powerful tools in creative writing — because it breaks the expected pattern of longer paragraphs, it forces the reader to slow down and pay attention.

3 Why writers use it

Paragraph Structure helps writers: organise ideas clearly so the reader isn't overwhelmed, control pacing and emphasis through paragraph length, and signal shifts in time, place, speaker, or focus without needing to state it directly.

In creative writing, paragraph structure is a genuine technique, not just organisation — a sudden very short paragraph after longer ones is one of the most effective tools for creating dramatic impact.

4 Where you'll spot it

Exam creative writing

Clear paragraphing is one of the first things examiners notice — a piece with no paragraph breaks reads as disorganised, whatever the content.

Journalism

Short, focused paragraphs are used deliberately so readers can follow and skim complex information easily.



Watch out!

Don't start a new paragraph for every single sentence out of habit — paragraph breaks should follow a genuine shift in idea, time, place or speaker, not just appear randomly.



Look here!

Save a **very short paragraph** for your most dramatic or important moment — it stands out far more when it's surrounded by longer ones.

5 Quick recap

Organises writing into blocks

One central idea per paragraph

Signals shifts in time or focus



You got this!

Try writing three paragraphs of build-up, then a single dramatic sentence as its own paragraph.